A Tale of Two Reports

In the years after World War I, the Government of India constituted two committees that considered the question of mercantile shipping in India. The documents generated by the two committees act not only as a lighthouse that warns of the lurking dangers that wrecked many an indigenous shipping venture but also provide excellent background material for our story.

The first was the Deck Passenger Committee constituted in 1921. Though its objective was to address the question of ‘standards of accommodation and sanitary conveniences’ for passengers—further narrowed down by the exclusion of pilgrim and emigrant traffic—at least some of the troubles that plagued shipping during the time of SSNCo find a place in the report. Undercutting by powerful, pre-existing companies remained a burning issue. An overwhelming number of non-official witnesses, and even official witnesses, emphatically declared that ‘new capital is debarred from entering the shipping trade through fear of the rate-war’. The report affirmed that ‘it was common knowledge’ that many earlier attempts had failed ‘partly owing to the rate war’. However, as could be expected, the committee was ‘averse to recommending more than the minimum intervention by the Government’.[17] While the report of the committee is useful as far as it goes, unfortunately the evidence provided to the committee does not seem to have been published and remains to be traced.

Thankfully this is not the case with the Indian Mercantile Marine Committee. Constituted in 1923, it had much wider terms of reference. While its report stands as an indictment of imperialism in Indian waters, the evidence volume is fabulous in its richness. Given the limited and fragmentary nature of the archive on SSNCo, it is some consolation to have these detailed depositions.

The committee had its origins in a resolution moved by P.S. Sivaswami Iyer in the Imperial Legislative Assembly. (Ironically, Sivaswami Iyer was the Advocate-General to the Government of Madras at the height of the